COM435 – Software Product and Process Management

Lab Practical

Week 4 – Generating Innovative Features & Product Differentiators

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By the end of Week 23 teams should have finalised VPCs and have a consolidated set of features. The purpose of this lab is to move beyond analysing existing products and begin creating innovative solutions of your own. Using a range of creativity techniques, your team will generate new ideas, enhancements and features that could provide additional value to users and help differentiate your product from existing competitors.

Task 1 – Review Your Current Findings

As a team, review all work completed so far, including:

- Competitor research
- Customer segments
- User needs
- Feature inventories
- Existing market gaps

Discuss the following:

- What common features appear across competitors?
- What frustrations do users currently experience?
- Which user needs are poorly addressed?
- Where could innovation create additional value?

This discussion should help focus your creativity efforts during the remainder of the lab.

Outcome for this task

- Shared understanding of current findings.
- Identification of potential innovation opportunities.

Task 2 – Generate Ideas Using Creativity Techniques

The objective of this activity is to generate as many ideas as possible.

Do not evaluate ideas at this stage.

Focus on quantity rather than quality, you will review these later for sanity.

Brainstorming

Generate ideas rapidly and encourage all team members to contribute.

Remember:

Avoid criticism.

Build on the ideas of others.

Record everything.

Encourage unusual suggestions.

Random Stimulus

Select a random product, service or activity and force connections between it and your chosen product idea.

Examples may include:

- Streaming services
- Video games
- Social media platforms
- Online marketplaces

Think about how elements of these products could inspire new features.

Worst Possible Idea

Intentionally generate terrible solutions before discussing how those ideas could be adapted into something useful.

Sometimes innovative concepts emerge from unlikely sources.

Outcome for this task

A large collection of potential ideas.

New perspectives on possible features and services.

Task 4 – Identifying Differentiators

Review all ideas generated so far.

Separate features into two categories:

Table Stakes

Features users would expect every solution in this market to offer.

Examples may include:

- Registration
- Login
- Search
- Notifications
- Profile management

Differentiators

Features that could make your product stand out from competitors.

These may include:

- Personalisation
- AI-assisted functionality
- Accessibility improvements
- Enhanced workflows
- Unique service offerings

Consider which features provide genuine user value rather than novelty alone.

Outcome for this task

- Categorised feature list.
- Initial shortlist of differentiator candidates.

Task 5 – Defining Potential USPs

Review your differentiator ideas and discuss:

- Which features solve real user problems?
- Which ideas are unique compared to competitors?
- Which ideas create the greatest user value?
- Which ideas are most aligned with your product vision?

Try to identify between 1 and 3 potential Unique Selling Points (USPs).

These do not need to be final decisions but should represent promising areas for further exploration.

Outcome for this task

- A shortlist of potential USPs.
- Stronger product vision.

Task 6 – Preparing for Week 5

As a team, consolidate all work completed to date.

Create a single feature inventory containing:

- Table-stake features
- Differentiator features
- Potential USPs

Consider ranking features according to:

- User value
- Product value
- Technical complexity
- Strategic importance

This prioritised feature list will become increasingly important as user stories are refined and MVP planning begins.

Outcome for this task

- Consolidated feature inventory.
- Prioritised list of candidate features.